SPACE TO ORGANIZE

Rental Decorating Checklist

A renter-friendly guide to making your place feel like home without permanent changes

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

- Check your lease and building rules first
- Plan color, lighting, textiles, and layout
- Choose removable and freestanding options
- Track purchases and room-by-room tasks
- Document the space and protect your deposit

Print it, fill it in, and use it at your own pace. This guide helps you make thoughtful choices before spending money or changing your space.

1. Start with the rules

Before decorating, check your lease and ask your landlord or property manager when unsure. Rules differ by property.

- ■ I reviewed my lease for decorating restrictions.
- ■ I know the rules for painting, wallpaper, nails, and drilling.
- ■ I checked whether adhesive products are permitted and how to remove them.
- ■ I know the rules for changing light fixtures or installing shelves.
- ■ I checked policies for window coverings and shared areas.
- ■ I will get written approval before changes that require it.
- ■ I photographed the room before decorating.
- ■ I saved receipts and instructions for removable items.

Questions for the landlord / property manager

Question	Answer / date
Are removable wall products allowed?	_____
Can I use adhesive hooks or picture strips?	_____
Are plug-in lamps allowed?	_____
Are there window-covering restrictions?	_____
What must be restored at move-out?	_____

2. Choose your decorating direction

Pick a simple starting point. Add personality without buying everything at once.

My room's style / mood: _____

My three main colors

Color	Where I will use it
Main neutral	_____
Secondary color	_____
Accent color	_____

Renter-friendly options to consider

- ■ Textiles: rugs, curtains, cushion covers, and throws.
- ■ Freestanding furniture: bookcases, side tables, and storage units.
- ■ Lighting: table lamps and approved plug-in lights.
- ■ Decor: framed art on furniture, leaning mirrors, and tabletop pieces.
- ■ Organization: baskets, drawer dividers, and freestanding shelves.
- ■ Wall decor: only removable products allowed by your lease and wall finish.
- ■ Plants in stable, water-safe containers.

My three priorities (comfort, privacy, storage, light, color, etc.):

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

3. Room-by-room checklist

Use this as a planning guide, not a requirement to buy everything.

Entryway

- ■ A place for keys and daily essentials
- ■ A shoe solution that fits
- ■ A mat or small basket, if permitted

Living room

- ■ Comfortable seating and clear walking paths
- ■ Layered lighting with lamps
- ■ A rug sized to the seating area
- ■ Baskets or closed storage for clutter

Bedroom

- ■ Curtains or privacy solution that follows the rules
- ■ Bedside light and reachable charging
- ■ Under-bed storage measured before buying
- ■ Soft textiles for warmth

Kitchen / dining

- ■ Drawer or shelf organizers sized to cabinets
- ■ A safe place for frequently used items
- ■ Removable solutions only if permitted

Bathroom

- ■ Caddy or baskets for daily products
- ■ Storage that follows property rules
- ■ Moisture-safe organization

Work / study corner

- ■ A desk that fits without blocking access
- ■ Task lighting
- ■ Cable organization
- ■ A home for paperwork and supplies

4. Measure before you buy

Record usable dimensions. Check product dimensions, assembly space, delivery route, and door swings.

Area / item	Available space	Dimensions checked?
Sofa / seating	_____	■
Rug	_____	■
Bookcase / shelf	_____	■
Curtains / window	_____	■
Bedside table	_____	■
Storage baskets	_____	■
Mirror / art	_____	■
Other	_____	■

Before placing furniture

- ■ Doorways and main walkways remain clear.
- ■ Windows, vents, radiators, and electrical panels remain accessible.
- ■ Tall furniture is stable and secured safely where allowed.
- ■ Plug-in cables are managed without trip hazards.
- ■ Items suit the room’s moisture, sunlight, and everyday use.

Notes / measurements to confirm:

_____
_____
_____

5. Purchase planner

Make a short list and buy in stages. Prioritize daily comfort and function.

Item	Room	Priority	Budget	Bought?
_____	_____	High / Med / Low	_____	■
_____	_____	High / Med / Low	_____	■
_____	_____	High / Med / Low	_____	■
_____	_____	High / Med / Low	_____	■
_____	_____	High / Med / Low	_____	■
_____	_____	High / Med / Low	_____	■

My decorating budget: _____ Spent so far: _____

Low-cost styling checklist

- ■ Rearrange what I already own before buying decor.
- ■ Use textiles to add color and texture.
- ■ Use lamps to improve lighting.
- ■ Group small decor on a tray to look intentional.
- ■ Use baskets or boxes to hide everyday clutter.
- ■ Choose a few meaningful pieces instead of filling every surface.

6. Protect your deposit and plan for move-out

Always follow your lease, manufacturer instructions, and landlord guidance. Removable products can still damage some finishes.

- ■ I kept original condition photos and move-in inspection records.
- ■ I checked the surface and product instructions before applying removable decor.
- ■ I kept instructions for products that need careful removal.
- ■ I did not paint, drill, or install anything without required permission.
- ■ I kept receipts and notes about approved changes.
- ■ I know what must be removed before moving out.
- ■ I will remove products slowly and according to instructions.
- ■ I will report damage promptly rather than conceal it.

Move-out reminders

Task	Completed / notes
Remove temporary decor	_____
Pack storage and furniture	_____
Clean and check surfaces	_____
Compare with move-in photos	_____
Return keys / complete inspection	_____

Remember: “Renter-friendly” does not automatically mean damage-free or allowed by every lease. Check first, follow product instructions, and choose reversible changes that suit your home.